

12TH ANNUAL FOOTCANDLE FILM FESTIVAL



The 2026 Footcandle FilmLAB

Weekend Filmmaking Competition
Public Screening of Films & Cash Prize to Winner
September 18th-21st, 2026

The **FilmLAB** is an event designed to challenge creative individuals to collaborate in competitive teams while racing against the clock to produce a one-of-a-kind short film.

Over a **60-hour period** your filmmaking team will write, shoot, and edit a short film based on the genre you draw at the Friday night FilmLAB kickoff event. By Monday morning your team's finished film is turned in to be judged and then screened in front of an audience the following night at the Footcandle Film Festival's following Thursday night FilmLAB Premiere event!

Recruit your own filmmaking team for the weekend! There's no limit to the size of your team, and it can consist of friends, colleagues, family members, or fellow students.



To register for the FilmLAB Competition, visit:
www.FootcandleFilmFestival.com



FilmLAB Timeline

Friday, September 18th – 7pm	FilmLAB KICKOFF @ SALT Block, Moretz Board Room; at least one member of your team must be in attendance!
Monday, September 21st – 8am	FilmLAB entries due (submitted online)
Thursday, September 24th – 7pm	All FilmLAB entries screened as part of a FilmLAB premiere event @ Hickory Community Theatre, Downtown Hickory, followed by drinks with fellow filmmakers
Sunday, September 27th – 7pm	Film Lab winner announced at the Footcandle Film Festival AWARDS CEREMONY @ Hickory Community Theatre

FilmLAB Rules and Guidelines

- The FilmLAB entry fee is **\$30 per team** (**\$20 per team** if half or more of the team is made up of current high school or college students).
- All teams are responsible for providing their own filmmaking equipment. Any type of gear is allowed, and we even wholeheartedly support and encourage the use of mobile cameraphones if desired.
- No prior work (scripting, effects, etc.) should be used in the entries. All content for the film should be generated during the FilmLAB 48-hour timeline.
- However, filmmaking teams may scout and secure filming locations prior to the FilmLAB weekend.
- All filmmaking team members must be present at the FilmLAB kickoff event on **Friday night, September 18th, at 7:00pm**.
- During the FilmLAB kickoff event, all filmmaking teams will:
 - draw a random **genre** that their film must adhere to
 - receive a single **prop** that must be incorporated into their film
 - receive a single line of **dialog** that must be included in their film
- Entries must run a minimum of **five minutes** (excluding credits) and maximum of **ten minutes** (with credits twelve minutes).
- All films are to be uploaded to a designated Dropbox folder by **8am on Monday, September 21st**. Teams need to ensure they calculate time into their production process to account for this.
- FilmLAB entries must not further hate speech or portray any negative stereotypes, and should aim for no more than a “PG-13” rating equivalent.
- Closing credits of the film should include the Footcandle Film Festival FilmLAB Logo (provided to all teams).
- The winning FilmLAB entry will be determined by an average of audience scores during the premiere screening at the Wednesday night COMING ATTRACTIONS event and scores determined by a panel of judges. The weighted averages of the two groups of scores are as follows: judges average score = 60%, Audience average score = 40%.

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